

CHAI

Despite tea cultivation beginning in India in the 1850s, the practice of taking tea, or chai, with milk and sugar became popular only in the latter half of the 19th century when British plantation owners introduced it to the masses. The rich creaminess of buffalo milk, traditionally used in India to make chai, complements the robustness of Indian teas, especially Assam. Although the high butterfat content in buffalo milk is preferred, any type of dairy-based milk can be used.

“Masalas,” or aromatic spices, have always been a key component of Indian cuisine. Hot beverages made with masalas were traditionally drunk for medicinal purposes. During the late 19th century, a marriage of these spices with milky, sweet tea resulted in the rich and spicy beverage we now know as Masala Chai (see recipe on pp182–83).



CHAI BREAK

The sheer number of chai stalls occupying the streets of India is a clear indication of the popularity of the drink. Both office workers and laborers alike can be seen taking tea in stalls at all hours of the day.

KULLARHS

Chai wallahs, or tea vendors, make Masala Chai from scratch with their own blend of spices, low-quality black tea, milk, and sugar. The chai is poured from a height and often served in small, lightly fired clay cups known as “kullarhs.” Hygienic and environmentally friendly, kullarhs are made of degradable clay and are discarded on the roadside after the chai has been consumed.

SPICED CHAI

Bursting with flavor and aroma, the Masala Chai’s kick comes from an assortment of spices including cloves, cinnamon, cardamom, and ginger.

